

Soil science

George worked at different jobs until his late 20s, when he was accepted at an agricultural college to study plant science. George quickly earned a reputation as a fantastic scientist. In 1896, he was invited to join the Tuskegee Institute in Alabama to conduct his own research. George liked science because it gave him a way to help people. He started looking for ways to improve life for farming families, many of whom had once been enslaved themselves.

There's a crater on the moon named in George's honor.



George traveled around to share his knowledge with farmers and teach them new techniques. He used a wagon as his classroom.



At first, farmers didn't want to grow crops that they couldn't sell, such as peanuts, even if these crops did improve the soil.

But, by 1915, George's crop rotation methods had turned the struggling farms in the American South into some of the country's biggest suppliers of agricultural products. Peanuts were now one of the most important crops grown in the US.



Crop rotation

Cotton was the main crop grown in the South. However, it used up all the nutrients in the soil, and fertilizer that helped the soil recover was expensive. George experimented with crop rotation, which means planting different crops each year. He discovered that growing peanuts, soybeans, and sweet potatoes helped the soil to recover lost nutrients.

George found new ways to use sweet potatoes other than just as food. He figured out that parts of the plant could be used to make fabric, rope, rubber, and glue!